



HOW DOES BJP'S LEADERSHIP DIFFER FROM CONGRESS?

"There is no reservation for the top slot in BJP"**L.K. ADVANI** LEADER OF THE OPPOSITION (LOK SABHA)

The first and foremost difference between our two organisations is this: The Congress is dynastic, the BJP is democratic. There is a reservation policy for the top slot in the Congress. It is reserved in perpetuity for members of the Nehru family. Now look in contrast to the BJP. In my party, leadership is not the birthright of any individual or family. I sometimes feel depressed that how brazenly an entire party has been appropriated and made into a family fiefdom and how slavishly Congressmen have resigned themselves to this appropriation. It is one of the saddest developments of Indian political evolution.

The three towering leaders from BJP—Dr Shyama Prasad Mookerjee who founded the Bharatiya Jan Sangh in 1951; Pandit Deen Dayal Upadhyaya, who was the chief ideologue and guide of the Jan Sangh; and Atal Bihari Vajpayee, became leaders on the strength of their own personality. They did not belong to any big family, nor did they have any great inheritance that brought them to the top.

India has so far had six Congress prime ministers out of which three have belonged to the Nehru family. Of the others, the tenure of Lal Bahadur Shastri was tragically short. However, both in the case of P.V. Narasimha Rao and Manmohan Singh, a conscious and sustained attempt has been made to emphasise that real power resides not at 7 Race Course Road but at 10 Janpath.

I used the word Kremlinisation in the context of the current Congress leadership when I criticised the present prime minister. I said this kind of situation prevailed only in the erstwhile Soviet Union. India is a democracy yet how is it that today 10 Janpath has become more important than 7 Race Course Road? It is this kind of Kremlinisation of Indian polity

that makes me criticise a person whom I still hold in great esteem. But I did say this is the weakest prime minister India has ever had. I feel sympathy for the present prime minister. His predicament is his own making. The authority of the office of prime minister is enormous.

The Congress culture has brought 'dynasty' even into the nomenclature of government schemes, in terms of projecting who is a great man of this country. I had an occasion to talk about this in the Parliament while debating the Motion of Thanks to President's address. I said I was both bemused and disturbed when I went through the address to see that all the schemes and projects mentioned in it have been named after one single family. Look at the list: Indira Gandhi National Tribal University, Rajiv Gandhi National Fellowship, Jawaharlal Nehru National Urban Renewal Mission... I said, Mr Prime Minister, hasn't India produced any other great men or women. Sixty years have passed and this country has produced people like Sardar Patel, Jaiprakash Narayan, Dr Ram Manohar Lohia, Dr Shyama Prasad Mookerjee, Annadurai, Morarji Desai... but not one of this strikes you, but only one family, only one dynasty? Mr Prime Minister, even a Narasimha Rao doesn't strike you? Dr Singh had no answer. The fact is that although he is the prime minister, he has only the title but no authority.

Another salient difference pertains to our contrasting approaches to coalition management. The credit of providing the first stable, successful and purposive coalition government goes to BJP and Atal Bihari Vajpayee. At one point we had over 24 parties in the NDA. But we scrupulously followed the coalition dharma. Indeed the very term coalition dharma is the BJP's contribution to the lexicon of

Indian democracy.

Contrast this with the way the Congress has been managing the United Progressive Alliance and its relations with the Left Front that provide crucial support to the Government. There is no mutual trust, no cohesive vision to a larger national goal. In the

RAVI S SAHNI



"HOW IS IT THAT 10 JANPATH HAS BECOME MORE IMPORTANT THAN 7 RACE COURSE ROAD?"

L.K. Advani